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Between Faith and Power

Church Leadership, Agency, and Peace with Justice in Tanzania

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Abstract

This thesis examines how leaders within the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania (ELCT) understand and exercise agency in relation to peace, justice, and political authority in the context of increasing democratic erosion and political repression in contemporary Tanzania. While Tanzania has historically been regarded as a relatively stable polity within East Africa, the 2025 general elections and their aftermath exposed significant tensions concerning shrinking civic space, state violence, and restrictions on freedom of expression. Against this background, the study investigates how church leaders navigate the relationship between prophetic witness, institutional survival, and political constraint. The study is grounded in a qualitative research design and is based on semi-structured interviews with church leaders and practitioners conected to the ELCT and affiliated organisations. The material is analysed through thematic analysis informed by Anthony Giddens' structuration theory and Hannah Arendt's theory of action, supplemented by the concepts of peace-with-justice, prophetic witness, and religion in the public sphere.

The findings demonstrate that participants consistently understood peace not merely as the absence of violence, but as inseparable from justice, human dignity, and freedom of expression. At the same time, the study identifies a significant tension between this theological understanding and the institutional practice of the church. The findings suggest that the ELCT's public silence in moments of political crisis is shaped by a combination of structural fragmentation, fear, financial dependency, and processes of state co-optation. Internal institutional divisions, difering theological interpretations of political responsibility, and the church's confederal structure further constrained the possibility of unified public action.

The thesis argues that religious agency in Tanzania is neither absent nor fully autonomous but negotiated within conditions of political pressure and institutional vulnerability. The study contributes to scholarship on religion and peacebuilding by demonstrating how faith-based actors may simultaneously reproduce and challenge structures of power in contexts of democratic backsliding. It further contributes to discussions on church-state relations in East Africa by analysing how moral authority, prophetic discourse, and institutional survival intersect within contemporary Tanzanian public life.

Keywords: Social justice, religious actors, peacebuilding, church-state relations, Tanzania

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List of Abbreviations

ELCT: Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania

KKKT: Kanisa la Kiinjili la Kilutheri Tanzania (ELCT but in Swahili)

FBO: Faith-Based Organisation

FPCT: Full Pentecostal Church of Tanzania

PPP: Public-Private Partnership

SKM: Svenska Missionssällskapet (Swedish Missionary Society)

Introduction

The relationship between religious institutions and political authority constitutes one of the enduring tensions in the study of civil society and public life. In contexts where democratic institutions are fragile or subject to active erosion, the question of whether religious actors can function as moral counterweights to state power becomes both analytically pressing and politically consequential. This study examines that tension in contemporary Tanzania, focusing on the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania (ELCT) as a case through which to investigate how religious leaders understand and exercise agency in relation to peace, justice, and political authority.

Tanzania has long been regarded as a comparatively stable polity within the East African region, yet this characterisation has come under increasing scholarly and empirical scrutiny. The 2025 general election exposed significant fractures in the country´s democratic fabric, with the principal opposition candidate arrested on charges widely assessed as politically motivated, the main opposition party formally disqualified from the electoral process, and subsequent civic unrest met with violent suppression and internet shutdowns. Freedom House downgraded Tanzania's status from Partly Free to Not Free in its 2025 country report, reflecting a broader pattern of democratic erosion that scholars have situated within the framework of competitive authoritarianism (Levitsky and Way, 2010).

It is within this context that the public role of the ELCT has come under heightened scrutiny. As the second largest Lutheran church in the world, the ELCT carries considerable moral authority within Tanzanian society, yet its response to political pressure has been contested. Public debate surrounding the church´s perceived silence, alongside concrete incidents of church leaders facing state intimidation and arrest ahead of the 2025 elections, raises important questions about how religious institutions navigate the competing demands of institutional integrity, theological vocation, and civic responsibility.

The aim of this study is to examine how leaders within the ELCT understand and exercise agency in relation to peace and justice in the current political context. The study draws theoretically on Giddens´ theory of structuration, Arendt's conception of power and public action, and the ecumenical concept of peace-with-justice and employs a qualitative methodology combining semi-structured interviews with key church actors and systematic analysis of official church documents and public statements.

This research builds on the authors prior work examining religious actors in conflict-affected contexts and aims to contribute to scholarly discussions on religion, democratic resilience, and peacebuilding, as well as to practical understanding of faith-based engagement in politically sensitive environments.

1.1 Research Questions and Problem Statement

Tanzania has long been regarded as a comparatively stable polity within the East African region. However, recent political development, most notably in the context of the 2025 elections, have raise significant concerns among scholars and observers regarding democratic backsliding, the contraction of civic space, and increasing pressure on civil society actors. It is within this shifting political landscape that the present study situates its inquiry into the public role of religious institutions.

Religious actors occupy a structurally distinctive position in Tanzanian society. The Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania (ELCT), as one of the country´s most prominent religious institutions and the 2nd largest Lutheran church in the world, holds considerable moral authority in public life. Yet the nature and limits of this authority become particularly complex in moments of political tension. Public criticism directed at the ELCT's perceived silence in the face of political unrest points to a deeper tension: how do church leaders negotiate the competing demands of institutional integrity, theological conviction, political constraint, and societal expectations.

These dynamics constitute the central problem this research seeks to address. The study examines how church leadership navigates the space between moral authority and political accommodation, and what this reveal about the conditions under which religious institutions either reinforce or challenge existing powerstructures.

Primary Research Question

How do leaders within the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania exercise and understand agency in relation to peace and justice in the current political context?

Sub-questions

- How is the concept of peace-with-justice articulated within church discourse and leadership statements?

- How do church leaders interpret their role in relation to political authority and societal conflict?
- What strategies do church actors employ to navigate political constraints while maintaining moral authority?
- Where internal disagreements have arisen within church leadership, how have these been understood and addressed?

1.2 Previous research

Scholarship on religion, politics, and development in Tanzania has expanded considerably over the last two decades and provides a rich background against which to situate the present inquiry into church leadership, agency, and peace-with-justice within the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania (ELCT). This chapter places the thesis in conversation with four overlapping bodies of research: (i) the Tanzanian state's regulation of religion and the model of secularism that frames it; (ii) faith-based organisations (FBOs) as development actors and political interlocutors of the state; (iii) the prophetic and public role of the ELCT; and (iv) the formation of pastors and the constitution of pastoral authority. The principal interlocutors throughout are Josephine Sundqvist (2017) and Johannes Habib Zeiler (2018), whose Uppsala dissertations together offer the most sustained recent treatment of the Tanzanian church-state field and of Lutheran institutional selfunderstanding. The ELCT's institutional development has been closely shaped by its historical ties to the Church of Sweden (Svenska kyrkan) and its predecessor, the Swedish Missionary Society (Svenska Missionssällskapet, SKM), whose missionary work in Tanzania dates to the nineteenth century. This long-standing relationship has created a sustained Swedish academic interest in the Tanzanian Lutheran context, with researchers affiliated with Uppsala University contributing to the field over several decades. The present study builds on this tradition and also reflects a more personal dimension. Conducting this research in Tanzania carries significant meaning for me, as this is my seventh time in the country and I have previously worked with the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania (ELCT) and in collaboration with partners connected to Swedish dioceses. These experiences have shaped both my academic interests and my understanding of the local context. The study has also benefited from established networks and the support of ACT Church of Sweden, which have been important in facilitating access to research participants.

State, secularism, and the framing of religion

Tanzanian secularism is widely described as a model in which the state holds a deliberately neutral position between religions. Sundqvist explains that "secularism is promoted as a means of ensuring that no religion gets a dominant position at the expense of another" and that Tanzania has adopted "residual secularism, meaning that the constitution is designed in such a way that all religions are entitled to equal freedom and protection, thus striving to uphold the neutrality of the state" (Sundqvist 2017: 74). She traces this to Nyerere, who "introduced a clear distinction between a secular state and a secular society […], by declaring Tanzania a secular stat, based on the assumption that the population is religious but not the state itself" (Sundqvist 2017: 74). The neutrality has, however, always been contested: "some of these scholars have proposed that the Tanzanian state is nominally secular but still dominated by strong church-state relationships" (Sundqvist 2017: 74).

Sundqvist also documents how that same state circumscribes religious speech. Quoting Bakari, she observes that "the Government occasionally denies permissions to religious groups seeking to hold demonstrations if there is a perceived likelihood that the gathering could lead to confrontation or ignite religious tensions" (Bakari 2007: 24, in Sundqvist 2017: 74). This movement is constitutional neutrality on one side, selective restriction on the other, and this is precisely the environment in which ELCT leaders today must speak and act.

Heilman and Kaiser resist a clash-of-civilisations reading of this environment and argue that, despite recurrent tensions, "religion has not served as a primary faultline for sustained political violence and conflict, although there are signs that this might be changing" (Heilman & Kaiser 2002: 691). Drawing on a national survey, they note that "78% of the respondents positively depicted relations between Muslims and Christians, while 86% also felt positively about the relationship between their religion and the state" (Heilman & Kaiser 2002: 692). This is an important corrective: it cautions against treating any ecclesial intervention as evidence of religious confrontation and frames the ELCT's public voice within a more layered set of cross-cutting cleavages.

Nyanto extends this reading historically. He argue that "while party and government leaders evoked people-centered development initiatives, the collapse of ujamaa in the 1980s left the country with an 'ideological vacuum that could not adequately be filled by the market ideology'" (Bakari & Ndumbaro 2006: 342, in Nyanto 2024: 63), a vacuum into which religious actors stepped. Wilk-Mhagama makes a parallel point, observing that after

liberalisation “FBOs have become part of a growing religious field which has repositioned itself toward the multiple opportunity and expectations of the established apex bodies to co-ordinate with each other and manage their relationships with the government” (Wilk-Mhagama 2016: 287). Taken this together, the works establish the structural conditions under which the ELCT today exercises agency.

Churches as development actors and the dilemma of dependency

Sundqvist’s central argument is that the entry of Tanzanian churches into contractual partnerships with the state has had a paradoxical effect on their independence. She finds that “church organisations have moved to centre stage and gained more influence as a consequence of the political and economic reforms” (Sundqvist 2017: 247), yet warns that “within the PPPs, it looks as if church organisations believe that their critical voice function in the public debate will be challenged as they move into more formalised public private partnerships” (Sundqvist 2017: 253). She is explicit about the implications: “state-dependency could make it more difficult to criticise flaws in the existing system and the way these are handled by the state” (Sundqvist 2017: 254). This is precisely the tension the present thesis seeks to examine in the ELCT’s leadership statements during a politically sensitive period.

The historical depth of the Christians Lutheran involvement matters here. Sundqvist documents how, in the 1990s, “Churches started opposing and challenging the state openly” (Sundqvist 2017: 79), and points to the Protestants’ Bagamoyo Statement in which “they spoke of the deteriorating political, economic and social conditions in the country and the need for the government to take appropriate action” (Sundqvist 2017: 79). These episodes form a precedent for ELCT self-understanding as both a partner and a critic of the state.

Sundqvist also identifies the ELCT specifically as an unusually nervous partner. She notes that “some church leaders, in particular from the ELCT case study, feared losing their full ownership of the church-based hospitals”, and that “several interviewees, in particular from the ELCT and the FPCT cases, argue that it is crucial that churches maintain a critical voice, in particular when they cooperate closely with a state that is limiting human rights” (Sundqvist 2017: 254-255). Names that the underlying risk in unmistakable terms: “the partnerships might lead to church organisations becoming domesticated by the state” (Sundqvist 2017: 255). The Lutheran case, in her reading, is therefore both more entangled with and more anxious about its relationship to public authority than the other denominations she studies.

Wilk-Mhagama reaches a similarly cautionary conclusion at the institutional level: “the secular state ought to resolve inter-religious issues. This can happen only if faith-based organizations are independent of the state. The situation in Tanzania is different. While Christian organizations seem to be autonomous and enjoy strong support from the believers, the Muslim organisations have no strong organisational structure” (Wilk-Mhagama 2016: 305). The structural asymmetry she describes, in which Christian institutions enjoy more organisational latitude but at the same time risk co-optation, frames the dilemma that ELCT leaders must navigate.

The prophetic mission of the ELCT

The historical baseline for any account of ELCT public agency is set by Per Frostin, who taught at the Lutheran Theological College Makumira from 1975 to 1979 and whose study of liberation theology in Tanzania and South Africa (originally 1988, republished 2021) remains the most theologically developed reading of the Tanzanian church-state field under Ujamaa. Frostin distinguishes three ways of conceiving the sacred, secular relationship, “the monistic, the dichotomic, and the dialectical” (Frostin 2021: 75) and argues that “Ujamaa theology does not represent a monistic or a dichotomic but an emerging dialectical conception” (Frostin 2021: 75). On his account, the vocation of the church in Tanzania is irreducibly political; he quotes Nyerere’s address to the Maryknoll Sisters, in which the first president warned that “Unless the Church, its members and its organizations, express God’s love for man by involvement and leadership in constructive protest against the present conditions of man, then it will become identified with injustice and persecution. If this happens, it will die, and, humanly speaking, deserve to die” (Nyerere, in Frostin 2021: 76). Frostin reads this not as an instrumentalisation of religion but as a theological judgement: “the alternatives in Nyerere’s statement are community and selfishness, not sacred and secular”, and “Nyerere suggests that a church deserves to die when it neglects its commitment to the common good” (Frostin 2021: 76). His own assessment of the Tanzanian churches in this period, however, is sober: “With the exception of the problem of corruption, the churches have been rather cautious in their prophetic ministry” (Frostin 2021: 72). This judgement provide a baseline against which the present thesis and Zeiler’s more recent findings can be read.

Where Sundqvist focuses on structural dynamics, Zeiler’s study of the ELCT clergy excavates how church leaders themselves articulate the church’s role. He observes that “the church acts and engages in the public sphere, positioning itself as an advocate for justice and peace, most recently in the widely discussed Easter Message from the bishops in the ELCT in 2018”

(Zeiler 2018: 191). His informant frame this engagement in prophetic terms. One bishop insists that "the church has to show the way. The church also has to advocate against evil things which are taking place within the society. That is also part of the prophetic voice of the church" (Informant G, in Zeiler 2018: 163). Another is more self-critical:

> If you listen to politicians in this country, they say that the church has the role to preach the Word of God, leave all other things to politicians, to economists, and so on and so forth. But as we see ourselves, the prophetic role of the church is also to address those issues which are affecting and impacting upon the life of Tanzanians. No, we haven't been very successful in that area. We have not been prophetic enough. (Informant B, in Zeiler 2018: 164)

Zeiler read these tensions historically and from an ecclesiological. One important reason for not being able to speak out more prophetically, on his informant's account, "has both historical and ecclesiological explanations", since "historically, the tight alliances between the missionaries and the colonial administration made the church reluctant to intervene or question the ruling powers but to stay loyal to the state authorities" (Zeiler 2018: 164). He adds that "what further hinders the ELCT from cultivating its prophetic voice is partly related to the fact that the church is still wrestling with its ecclesiological self-understanding, which at present prevents the Lutherans in Tanzania from speaking with one voice" (Zeiler 2018: 165). The ELCT's difficulty in articulating a unified public position is, on his account, not principally a question of courage but of ecclesial structure. The prophetic role is anchored theologically rather than instrumentally. Zeiler's informants describe the diaconal vocation of the church as pointing "towards the vision of a prophetic church advocating for justice and integrity for all people in the society" (Zeiler 2018: 161). These findings are directly relevant to the present thesis's question of how leaders navigate political pressure while seeking to maintain moral authority.

Ministerial formation and pastoral authority

The fourth dimension Zeiler contributes is an account of how pastors themselves are made. He argues that "there are three legitimising components that constitute pastoral authority in the ELCT; theological education and teaching, ordination, and moral character" (Zeiler 2018: 185). Theological education is on his reading neither incidental nor merely academic; it is a form of governance: "the discourse of theological education is loaded with high expectations and far-reaching demands for both individuals and collectivises" (Zeiler 2018: 185), pointing

to “the overall intention of the educational enterprise: to train, shape, and equip individuals for the ordained ministry in the ELCT” (Zeiler 2018: 185-186). Pastors are explicitly trained “to lead the ELCT into the future, a study process through which they are supposed to be changed, challenged, transformed, and re-directed” (Zeiler 2018: 160).

This matters for any study of ELCT agency in political moments. The pastoral oath itself, Zeiler shows, binds candidates “to ‘un-tirelessly have a worship habit’, to ‘be ready to control [their] moral behaviour’ and to ‘be ready to work wherever [they] will be sent’” (Zeiler 2018: 187-188), framing pastoral life as a vocation under sustained moral and institutional surveillance. The agency available to a Lutheran bishop or pastor in Tanzania is therefore always agency mediated by the institutional architecture that produced them, an institutional fact that any account of how they exercise peace-with-justice must take seriously.

Gaps and contribution

Taken together, the studies surveyed here frame the questions of the present thesis but also leave specific gaps. Sundqvist’s analysis is anchored in the health sector and ends in 2017; her own concluding remarks call for further study of “church-state relationships in light of shrinking space” and of “the risks of aligning agendas with the demands of the Tanzanian state” (Sundqvist 2017: 255). Zeiler concentrates on theological formation rather than on contemporary political engagement, and his most recent reference point is the 2018 Easter Message of the ELCT bishops (Zeiler 2018: 191). Wilk-Mhagama (2016), Nyanto (2024), and Heilman and Kaiser (2002) provide important contextual scaffolding but do not focus on ELCT leadership specifically. None of these studies addresses the post-2025 election context, nor the way bishops themselves articulate peace-with-justice in moments of acute political pressure. The present thesis builds on the foundations laid by Sundqvist and Zeiler and extends their lines of inquiry into a more recent and more politically charged moment in Tanzanian public life.

Theoretical Framework

This chapter develops the theoretical framework that guides the analysis of faith-based actors in peacebuilding context. The framework brings together two primary theoretical traditions, Anthony Giddens’ structuration theory and Hannah Arendt’s theory of action, and supplements them with three concepts drawn from peace studies, political theology, and the sociology of religion: peace-with-justice, prophetic witness, and religion in the public sphere.

Together they provide the tools needed to examine how religious communities navigate structural constraints, exercise agency, and engage contested public spaces in the pursuit of justice and peace.

2.1 Structuration Theory

Anthony Giddens' structuration theory, as set out in The Constitution of Society (1984), provides this study with a vocabulary for analysing how faith-based actors operate within and upon the social structures that shape conflict. The theory's central is that structure and agency are not opposed forces but mutually constitutive dimensions of social life. Giddens calls this the 'duality of structure,' formulating it as follows: the structural properties of a social system are "both the medium and the outcome of the practices they recursively organise" (Giddens, 1984: 25). This means that structures are not external cages bearing down on actors from above; they are reproduced through the very practices of those who inhabit them and can therefore also be gradually transformed through those same practices. For faith-based peacebuilders, this is analytically consequential: they are neither passive victims of structural violence nor unconstrained agents acting in a vacuum, but knowledgeable actors who draw on inherited rules and resources while simultaneously contributing to their reproduction or alteration.

The reason structuration theory is indispensable for this study is that it holds the tension between constraint and possibility without collapsing into either determinism or voluntarism. Conflict-affected societies are shaped by deep structural legacies, and any account of religious peacebuilding that ignores this will be analytically shallow. At the same time, structure in Giddens' sense is never simply constraining it is "both constraining and enabling" (Giddens, 1984: 169). The same institutional resources that can entrench division can also serve as the basis for transformative action. This double character of structure is central to understanding how religious communities occupy ambivalent positions in conflict settings, at once implicated in the reproduction of division and capable of contributing to its transformation.

Structure

In Giddens' framework, structure refers not to observable institutions but to the rules and resources that actors draw upon in their practices. Rules are the generalisable procedures through which social life is organised; resources include allocative resources, that is, material capacities, and authoritative resources, that is, the capacity to organise and coordinate persons. Giddens defines structure precisely as "rules and resources" (Giddens, 1a984, cited

in Whittington, 2015: 148), a formulation that invites attention to the specific mix of normative frameworks, material assets, and relational authority that actors bring to any given situation. For faith-based actors in divided societies, the structural landscape is layered and complex. It encompasses formal political and legal frameworks, the historical legacy of religious institutions' entanglement with violence or solidarity, and the authoritative weight of theological traditions that shape what can credibly be said and done in the name of faith.

Understanding structure in this relational way allows the analyst to move beyond descriptive accounts of what religious organisations do, toward questions about how the rules and resources they deploy are produced, distributed, and contested. It also allows for a serious engagement with the ways in which religious institutions can perpetuate structural violence, not only by active complicity but by the silent reproduction of arrangements that exclude, marginalise, or silence groups. As Giddens argues, "the duality of structure whereby encounters are organized in and through the intersections of practical and discursive consciousness" (Giddens, 1984: 72) means that even routine practices carry structural significance: what appears natural or unremarkable may in fact be reproducing patterns of domination that peacebuilding seeks to disrupt.

Agency

Giddens defines agency as the continuous capacity of actors to make a difference in the world, to intervene in a situation in ways that alter what would otherwise have occurred. This capacity is bound up with what he calls practical consciousness: the competent, largely pre-reflective knowledge through which agents navigate their social worlds. In Whittington's summary of Giddens, agents are "more knowledgeable about their practice than they can actually tell, and they constantly monitor and adjust this practice in order to achieve their purposes" (Whittington, 2015: 149). Agency, is not the grand gesture of the heroic individual but the ordinary, ongoing competence of persons who act in ways that matter, even when they cannot fully articulate why or how.

For this study, the concept of agency resists reductive explanations that treat religious peacebuilders as mere instruments of institutional interests, ideological commitments, or external pressures. It attributes genuine authorship to their choices while acknowledging that this agency is always exercised under conditions that are not of their making, and with consequences that regularly escape their intentions. The combination of real capacity and real constraint is precisely what makes peacebuilding a meaningful object of analysis: it is neither

structurally overdetermined nor voluntaristic free, but a site of ongoing, practical negotiation between inherited conditions and transformative possibility.

Transformative Capacity

Transformative capacity refers to the ability of actors to produce change within and upon existing structures. In Giddens' framework, this is closely tied to his concept of power, understood not as a possession but as a relational capacity to achieve outcomes. Religious communities in conflict settings often possess a distinctive form of transformative capacity that derives from sources not easily reducible to material resources. Their moral authority, their access to transnational networks, and the social trust accumulated through generations of presence in communities can constitute a significant resource for peacebuilding, particularly in contexts where state institutions have lost legitimacy. Giddens' conception of "the enabling aspects of structure" (Gidden, 1884: 169) is directly relevant here: the very resources that authoritative religious traditions place at the disposal of actors, including shared narratives of justice, forgiveness, and solidarity, are structural in character, and their deployment in peacebuilding constitutes precisely the kind of transformative practice that structuration theory helps to illuminate.

2.2 Hannah Arendt's Theory of Action

Hannah Arendt's theory of action, as developed in The Human Condition (1958), complements structuration theory by attending to the specifically public and ethical dimensions of meaningful action. Where Giddens focuses on the recursive interplay of structure and practice, Arendt is concerned with what happens when human beings appear among their peers, commit themselves to shared causes, and take irreversible moral responsibility for what they do. Her framework is particularly suited to analysing faith-based actors who enter public life not primarily as institutional representatives pursuing strategic interests, but as moral subjects making claims about justice and the character of the shared world.

Public Action

The foundation of Arendt's political thought is the concept of plurality: the condition that human beings are, as she writes, "all the same, that is, human, in such a way that nobody is ever the same as anyone else who ever lived, lives, or will live" (Arendt, 1958: 8). It is this irreducible plurality, the fact that action always takes place among distinct others who cannot be collapsed into a single will or interest, that gives political life its specific character. Action

and speech, for Arendt, are inseparable from disclosure: “Action and speech go on between men, as they are directed toward them, and they retain their agent-revealing capacity even if their content is exclusively objective” (Arendt, 1958: 182). To act publicly is always, simultaneously, to reveal something about who one is.

This dimension of Arendt’s framework has direct relevance for the study of faith-based peacebuilding. When a religious community steps into a conflict zone to mediate, testify, or advocate, it is not only pursuing an outcome; it is disclosing its identity and commitments in a public that holds it accountable. Arendt describes the courage required for this as “leaving one’s private hiding place and showing who one is, in disclosing and exposing oneself (Arendt, 1958: 186). The decision to act publicly in the name of reconciliation or justice is therefore always a risk: it creates a visible, committed identity that can be challenged, co-opted, or undermined. Reading faith-based engagement through this lens reveals it as something more than a strategic calculation; it is an act of political self-disclosure that carries meaning independent of its immediate outcomes. Furthermore, Arendt insists that public action always leaves a trace in the relational web of human life: “The disclosure of the “who” through speech, and the setting of a new beginning through action, always fall into an already existing web” of relationships whose consequences no single actor can fully control (Arendt, 1958: 184). Peacebuilding initiatives, however, carefully designed, are therefore always entering into a field of interactions, histories, and relationships that exceed them.

Natality

Among Arendt’s most original contributions to political thought is the concept of natality. Rooted in the sheer fact that human beings are born, natality names the capacity for genuine new beginnings that is inscribed in human action. Arendt argue that action ‘has the closest connection with the human condition of natality; the new beginning inherent in birth can make itself felt in the world only because the newcomer possesses the capacity of beginning something anew, that is, of acting’ (Arendt, 1958: 9). So fundamental is this capacity that Arendt makes a striking claim: “natality, and not mortality, may be the central category of political, as distinguished from metaphysical, thought” (Arendt, 1958: 9). Political life is not, as much classical philosophy assumed, primarily oriented toward death and finitude; it is animated by the capacity to begin, to introduce something genuinely unprecedented into the world.

The full political force of this concept is stated in one of the most compelling passages of The Human Condition:

> The miracle that saves the world, the realm of human affairs, from its normal, natural ruin is ultimately the fact of natality, in which the faculty of action is ontologically rooted. It is, in other words, the birth of new men and the new beginning, the action they are capable of by virtue of being born (Arendt, 1958: 246).

For the study of religion and peacebuilding, natality does two distinct kinds of work. On one hand, it provides a philosophical grounding for what might otherwise appear as naive optimism: the conviction that even the most entrenched cycles of violence are not ontologically sealed, that genuine transformation remains possible regardless of how deeply structured the conflict appears. On the other hand, natality also names the radical fragility of new beginnings: what is genuinely new is also genuinely vulnerable. Reconciliation initiatives, like all new beginnings, are always at risk of being reversed, co-opted, or overwhelmed by the structural forces they seek to transform. The resonance between Arendt's concept and the theological motifs of renewal, new creation, and reconciliation that animate many faith traditions is not incidental; it reflects a shared conviction that the world is not closed to transformation.

Moral Responsibility

Arendt's account of moral responsibility emerges most sharply from her analysis of political evil. In her reporting on the trial of Adolf Eichmann, she coined the phrase the 'banality of evil' to describe how bureaucratic compliance and the suspension of independent judgment could make ordinary persons complicit in atrocity. The inverse implication is that genuine moral agency requires active, independent judgment; it cannot be delegated to institutions, dissolved into collective guilt, or hidden behind the performance of a role. Each actor who enters the public realm must take personal responsibility for what they do and what they fail to do.

For faith-based peacebuilders, this emphasis on judgment and individual accountability is both demanding and clarifying. It insists that acting in the name of a religious tradition or institution does not dissolve personal responsibility; if anything, it intensifies it, because the moral claims embedded in that tradition are now being staked in public. Arendt argues that "Action is, in fact, the one miracle-working faculty of man" (Arendt, 1958: 246), but this

capacity comes with an irreversible weight: once an action is undertaken, it cannot be undone, only responded to. For religious actors whose traditions already carry strong norms of accountability, solidarity, and the moral seriousness of public commitment, Arendt's framework provides a non-theological vocabulary for precisely these convictions.

2.3 Supporting Concepts

The principal theoretical frameworks are grounded and contextualised through three concepts that have been developed at the intersection of peace studies, political theology, and the sociology of religion. Each concept addresses a distinct dimension of faith-based public engagement: the normative vision that orients peacebuilding work, the specific mode of public speech through which religious actors assert that vision, and the contested question of the legitimacy of religious voices in pluralist political life.

Peace-with-Justice

The concept of peace-with-justice rests on a foundational distinction developed by Johan Galtung in his seminal 1969 article in the Journal of Peace Research. Galtung distinguishes between two forms of peace: negative peace, understood as the "absence of personal violence," and positive peace, defined as the "absence of structural violence", referring to the two together as opposite sides of a single coin (Galtung, 1969: 183). The concept of structural violence is central to this distinction. Galtung defines it as violence that is "structural, built into structure" rather than attributable to any individual actor. His illustration is sharp: "when one million husbands keep one million wives in ignorance there is structural violence" (Galtung, 1969: 171). A peace that consists only in the cessation of direct violence, while leaving intact the structural arrangements that produce deprivation, exclusion, and inequality, is on this account not peace at all but the management of conflict in the interests of those who benefit from existing arrangements.

John Paul Lederach, drawing on his work as a mediator in Central America, offers a complementary and evocative formulation of the same challenge through his reading of Psalm 85:10. In village meetings during the Nicaraguan peace process, Lederach encountered the phrase: "Truth and mercy have met together; peace and justice have kissed" (Lederach, 1997: 28). From this encounter he develops his argument that reconciliation requires holding together what political processes are tempted to separate: "Reconciliation, I am suggesting, involves the creation of the social space where both truth and forgiveness are validated and joined together, rather than being forced into an encounter in which one must win out over the

other" (Lederach, 1997: 29). For Lederach, "reconciliation represents a social space. Reconciliation is a locus, a place where people and things come together" (Lederach, 1997: 29).

This concept is essential for this study because it provides the normative horizon against which faith-based peacebuilding activities are assessed. It distinguishes genuinely transformative engagement, which seeks structural change alongside relational healing, from approaches that merely stabilise existing inequalities by restoring surface calm. For religious communities whose traditions carry strong commitments to justice and human dignity, peace-with-justice is not simply a political programme but a theological imperative.

Prophetic Witness

Prophetic witness designates a mode of public religious engagement in which faith communities speak truth to power: naming injustice, confronting the ideological legitimation of oppression, and orienting communities toward an alternative social order. The concept is rooted in the biblical prophetic tradition, but its significance extends well beyond its scriptural origins. Walter Brueggemann, in The Prophetic Imagination, describes the task of prophetic ministry in terms that are at once theological and political: "It is the task of prophetic ministry to bring the claims of the tradition and the situation of enculturation into an effective interface. That is, the prophet is called to be a child of the tradition, one who has taken it seriously in the shaping of his or her own field of perception and system of language, who is so at home in that memory that the points of contact and incongruity with the situation of the church in culture can be discerned and articulated with proper urgency" (Brueggemann, 2018: 2).

Brueggemann identifies two inseparable dimensions of this prophetic task. On one side, "the alternative consciousness to be nurtured serves to criticize in dismantling the dominant consciousness". On the other, it "serves to energize persons and communities by its promise of another time and situation toward which the community of faith may move" (Brueggemann, 2018: 3-4). Neither dimension can be reduced to the other: critique without energising vision risks becoming mere negation, while an energising vision that avoids honest confrontation with injustice risks becoming a form of wishful consolation. Brueggemann is also insistent that the prophetic task is not primarily reactive: "prophetic ministry has to do not primarily with addressing specific public crises but with addressing, in season and out of

season, the dominant crisis that is enduring and resilient, of having our alternative vocation co-opted and domesticated" (Brueggemann, 2018: 3).

Read through Arendt's theory of action, prophetic witness is a form of public disclosure in which faith communities stake their identity in a shared political space. It is not simply advocacy but a particular kind of appearance: one that makes claims about what justice requires and what human dignity demands, and that holds the actor to those claims in the sight of others. This combination of moral commitment and public accountability is what distinguishes prophetic witness from both detached commentary and purely interest-driven lobbying.

Religion in the Public Sphere

The question of how and whether religious voices can legitimately contribute to pluralist public life has been one of the most contested issues in contemporary political philosophy and the sociology of religion. For much of the twentieth century, the dominant liberal assumption held that the privatisation of religion was both a sociological inevitability and a normative requirement. This assumption was challenged decisively by José Casanova in Public Religions in the Modern World (1994). The central thesis of Casanova's study is stated directly: "religious traditions throughout the world are refusing to accept the marginal and privatized role which theories of modernity as well as theories of secularization had reserved for them" (Casanova, 1994: 5). This process of deprivatisation, as Casanova terms it, involves religious institutions that "refuse to restrict themselves to the pastoral care of individual souls and continue to raise questions about the interrelation of private and public morality and to challenge the claims of states and markets to be exempt from extraneous normative considerations" (Casanova, 1994: 5-6).

A normative dimension is added to this sociological diagnosis by Jürgen Habermas, whose thinking on religion in the public sphere has undergone significant revision. In his 2005 Holberg Prize lecture, Habermas argues that the secular state has a genuine interest in the contributions of religious voices: "The liberal state has an interest of its own in unleashing religious voices in the political public sphere, for it cannot know whether secular society would not otherwise cut itself off from key resources for the creation of meaning and identity" (Habermas, 2005: 8). This is not an uncritical endorsement of religious public engagement. Habermas insists on the conditions under which it can be legitimate, arguing that "the liberal ethics of citizenship requires from both, religious and secular citizens, complementary

learning processes" (Habermas, 2005: 12). Religious citizens are asked to translate their contributions into terms accessible to those who do not share their commitments; secular citizens are asked to engage genuinely with what those contributions might offer.

Together, Casanova's empirical analysis and Habermas' normative framework provide this study with a lens for examining the conditions under which faith-based peacebuilding constitutes a legitimate and constructive form of public engagement, and the conditions under which it risks becoming a vehicle for interests or exclusive identities. The question is not whether religious voices belong in the public sphere, but how their engagement can contribute to rather than undermine the shared conditions of pluralistic democratic life. The theoretical framework constructed in this part operates on three interlocking levels. Giddens' structuration theory provides the sociological architecture: it equips the analysis with concepts of structure, agency, and transformative capacity that can account for the weight of inherited conditions without foreclosing the possibility of change. Arendt's theory of action adds the political and ethical dimension: it foregrounds the public, relational, and morally consequential character of the choices that faith-based actors make when they enter shared spaces of deliberation and conflict. The supporting concepts of peace-with-justice, prophetic witness, and religion in the public sphere then connect these general frameworks to the specific normative aspirations, rhetorical modes, and contested legitimacy of religious engagement in divided societies. The analysis that follows draws on all three levels of the framework to examine how faith-based actors in Tanzania have navigated the tensions between structural constraint and transformative agency, between prophetic conviction and political pragmatism, and between the particular claims of religious tradition and the shared demands of pluralistic public life.

Methodology

This study employs a qualitative research design, using in-depth, semi-structured interviews to explore how leaders within the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania understand and exercise agency in relation to peace, justice, and political authority. Qualitative research was chosen because it is well suited to investigating complex social phenomena and the meanings individuals ascribe to their experiences and institutional roles. As Kvale and Brinkmann observe, the qualitative research interview "tries to understand the world from the subjects' points of view, to unfold the meaning of their lived world, and to describe their experiences as they are lived before they are theoretically explained" (Kvale and Brinkmann, 2009: 1). This

orientation aligns directly with the present study's aim to centre the perspectives and interpretive frameworks of church leaders themselves, rather than to impose external categories upon their practice.

Within this qualitative framework, the study takes an exploratory and interpretive approach. No experimental manipulation or quantitative measurement is involved. Instead, the goal is to interpret participants' perspectives and experiences in their real-world institutional and political context. The design is cross-sectional, focused on a particular case at a specific and historically significant moment, namely the ELCT and its leadership during and immediately following the 2025 Tanzanian electoral period. The rationale for this approach is that it provides the flexibility to probe unexpected topics as they emerge and to adapt to the concerns and framings that participants introduce, yielding a richer and more contextually grounded understanding than a structured or quantitative approach would permit (Bryman, 2016).

The methodological approach is also informed by critical perspectives within the study of religion and religious institutions. Freiberger notes that comparative studies of religion have faced important critiques, including concerns that they may "decontextualize and essentialize religious phenomena" (Freiberger, 2019: 3). In other words, scholars must be careful not to strip religious communities from their context or reduce them to monolithic essences. While this thesis does not directly compare multiple religious groups or traditions, it remains attentive to these cautions. The analysis is situated firmly within the specific socio-political and institutional context of the ELCT in contemporary Tanzania, in order to avoid generalisations that might flatten the particularity of the church's situation or treat its leadership as a uniform and undifferentiated body. By grounding the findings in participants' own words and institutional contexts, the study strives to produce an account that is analytically rigorous without sacrificing fidelity to the complexity of the lived and institutional realities it seeks to understand.

3.1 Participants

The study involved eight participants connected to the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania, selected based on their professional roles and their direct engagement with questions of church leadership, institutional governance, and public life. As Bryman notes, not all forms of social research prioritise representative samples; instead, qualitative research employs sampling principles "based not on the idea of representativeness but on the notion that samples should be selected on the basis of their appropriateness to the purposes of the

investigation" (Bryman, 2016: 10). In the present study, participants were therefore selected purposively, since the depth, relevance, and specificity of the perspectives they were positioned to offer in relation to the study's research questions. This approach reflects the broader epistemological orientation of qualitative interviewing, which, as Brinkmann and Kvale articulate, "attempts to understand the world from the subjects' points of view, to unfold the meaning of peoples' experiences, to uncover their lived world prior to scientific explanations" (Brinkmann and Kvale, 2018: 16). Eight participants were judged sufficient to generate analytically rich and thematically meaningful material given the focused and specialised nature of the inquiry.

Participants were identified and recruited through two principal access routes. The first was the researcher's prior professional relationships developed during an internship placement with the ELCT in Tanzania between 2018 and 2019. The trust and institutional familiarity cultivated during that period proved instrumental in gaining access to individuals who might not have been reachable through more formal or unfamiliar channels. The second access route was through the facilitation of Lorentz Forsberg, regional representative for ACT Church of Sweden in Tanzania and East Africa, whose professional networks within the ELCT enabled contact with several additional key informants.

The participant group comprises individuals occupying a range of roles within the ELCT and related organisations, including a diocesan bishop, a dean at a church-affiliated university, a managing director of a church department, programme executives working within areas of gender, health, and evangelisation, and a country director of an internationally affiliated Lutheran organisation. This diversity of institutional positions was considered analytically advantageous, as it enabled the study to gather perspectives on church leadership, internal decision-making, and the negotiation of political pressures from multiple levels and locations within the ELCT structure, rather than from a single institutional vantage point. To protect participant confidentiality, each interviewee has been assigned an alphabetical code running from A to H, used consistently throughout the analysis in place of names or other identifying information. This measure was considered particularly important given the politically sensitive nature of the study's subject matter and the context of documented state pressure on religious actors in Tanzania at the time of the fieldwork.

3.2 Data Collection: Semi-Structured Interviews

The primary method of data collection consisted of semi-structured interviews conducted individually with each of the eight participants. This method was selected as particularly well suited to the aims of the study, as it combines a degree of thematic structure with the flexibility necessary to allow participants to elaborate on their experiences, introduce perspectives not anticipated by the researcher, and speak in their own terms about complex and at times sensitive subjects. As Brinkmann and Kvale observe, "a qualitative research interview attempts to understand the world from the subjects' points of view, to unfold the meaning of peoples' experiences, to uncover their lived world prior to scientific explanations" (Brinkmann and Kvale, 2018: 16). This epistemological orientation is central to the rationale for choosing semi-structured interviewing as the primary method of data collection in the present study, as the research questions are concerned precisely with how church leaders themselves understand, articulate, and navigate their institutional roles and public responsibilities in a specific and politically charged context.

Semi-structured interviewing occupies a position between the rigidity of fully structured interviews, in which questions are fixed and predetermined, and the openness of unstructured interviews, in which the researcher exercises minimal direction over the conversation. In the semi-structured format, the researcher prepares an interview guide containing a set of themes and questions to be addressed, while retaining the flexibility to follow the particular direction a conversation takes, to probe unexpected but analytically relevant topics as they arise, and to adapt the ordering and framing of questions to the individual participant and the flow of the interview. This flexibility is particularly valuable in a study of this kind, where participants occupy different institutional positions and may therefore foreground different aspects of the themes under investigation.

An interview guide was developed in advance of the fieldwork, organised around six thematic areas: participants' backgrounds and institutional roles within the ELCT; their understandings of peace, justice, and the church's public discourse; the relationship between the ELCT and political authority in the contemporary Tanzanian context; internal dynamics and decision-making processes within the church; the constraints and strategies shaping the church's public engagement; and participants' reflections on the church's future role in Tanzanian society. The guide was designed to function as an orienting framework rather than a fixed script, ensuring that certain core themes were addressed consistently across all interviews while preserving the openness necessary for participants to introduce their own framings and concerns. Where

contextually appropriate, a supplementary question regarding experiences during the period surrounding the 2025 elections was also introduced.

Prior to the interview, participants were provided with a written consent form outlining the purpose of the study, the voluntary nature of their participation, their right to decline any question or withdraw from the study at any point without consequence, and the measures in place to protect their confidentiality. With the participant's permission, all interviews were audio-recorded to ensure accuracy of transcription and to allow the researcher to maintain a natural conversational engagement during the interview itself. Interviews were conducted in English and lasted approximately 45 to 75 minutes. Following completion, all recordings were transcribed in full by the researcher and subsequently reviewed against the original audio to correct any transcription errors and to annotate relevant non-verbal elements where these were considered to carry interpretive significance.

It is worth acknowledging that the conduct of interviews in a politically sensitive context introduces methodological considerations. Given the documented climate of state pressure on religious actors in Tanzania during the period of fieldwork, it is possible that some participants exercised a degree of caution in their responses, particularly in relation to questions concerning the church's relationship with political authority. The researcher sought to mitigate this through consistent assurances of confidentiality, the use of open and non-leading questions, and an attentiveness to the boundaries participants appeared to set during each conversation. These dynamics are acknowledged as a contextual feature of the data and are addressed further in the sections on researcher reflexivity and delimitations below.

3.3 Data Analysis: Thematic Analysis

The interview material was analysed using thematic analysis, following the approach outlined by Braun and Clarke. Thematic analysis is described by Braun and Clarke as "a method for identifying, analysing and reporting patterns (themes) within data" which "minimally organizes and describes your data set in (rich) detail" while also allowing the researcher to interpret "various aspects of the research topic" (Braun and Clarke, 2006: 79). This approach was selected because the study's research questions are concerned with the meanings, patterns, and tensions that emerge across the data, rather than with the frequency of occurrence of responses. Its flexibility makes it well suited to research that is exploratory and interpretive in character, as is the case here.

The analytical process followed Braun and Clarke's six-stage framework. As they outline, this moves through familiarisation with the data, generating initial codes, searching for themes, reviewing themes, defining and naming themes, and finally producing the report (Braun and Clarke, 2006: 86-93). In the present study, following the completion of transcription, the interview data were read closely on multiple occasions to develop a thorough familiarity with the material before any formal coding began. Initial codes were then generated both inductively, emerging directly from the data, and deductively in relation to the study's theoretical framework and research questions. As Braun and Clarke emphasise, thematic analysis is "not a linear process" but is rather "more recursive" in character, with the analyst moving back and forth between the data and the developing analytical framework (Braun and Clarke, 2006: 86). Codes were subsequently organised into broader thematic clusters, which were reviewed, refined, and named through an iterative process of sustained engagement with the material.

Analytical attention was directed towards four intersecting dimensions that reflect the study's theoretical and empirical concerns: the discursive construction of peace and justice within church leadership discourse; narratives of moral authority and institutional responsibility; expressions of agency and accounts of structural constraint; and the management of internal disagreement and external political pressure. Throughout the process, the researcher maintained a reflexive awareness of the interpretive choices involved in coding and theme development, consistent with the active role of the researcher emphasised by Braun and Clarke (Braun & Clarke, 2006: 80).

3.4 Terminology, Positionality, and Ethical Considerations

Researching religious leadership in a context of political sensitivity and institutional complexity demands careful attention to the language, assumptions, and interpretive frameworks brought into the field. As Freiberger notes, comparative studies of religion have faced important critiques, including concerns that they may "decontextualize and essentialize religious phenomena" (Freiberger, 2019: 3). This caution is taken seriously throughout the present study. The analysis is situated firmly within the specific socio-political and institutional context of the ELCT in contemporary Tanzania, and the study resists any tendency to reduce church leadership to a monolithic or uniform category.

Several terminological clarifications are warranted at the outset. The term agency is used throughout this study in the Giddensian sense, referring to what Giddens describes as the

capacity of human actors to "make a difference" within the structural conditions that shape their situation, understood not as freedom from constraint but as the exercise of meaningful action within and upon existing structures (Giddens, 1984: 14). Peace-with-justice is used as a normative theological concept denoting the inseparability of sustainable peace from structural justice and the redress of inequality, as articulated within ecumenical Lutheran discourse. Political authority is understood broadly to encompass formal state institutions as well as the exercise of political power through legal, institutional, and coercive mechanisms. The term church leadership refers to ordained and senior lay leaders within the ELCT who hold positions of institutional responsibility, including bishops, deans, departmental directors, and programme executives.

3.4.1 Ethical Considerations

The research was conducted in accordance with the ethical guidelines of Uppsala University and the broader principles governing research involving human participants. Each participant was provided with a written informed consent document prior to the interview, which outlined the purpose of the study, the nature of participation, the confidentiality measures in place, and the participant's right to withdraw at any time without consequence. Participants were also informed that audio recordings would be deleted upon completion of transcription and that all data would be stored securely and accessed only by the researcher.

Given that the study engages with politically sensitive subject matter in a context characterised by significant restrictions on civic expression and documented instances of state intimidation of religious leaders, particular care was taken to assess and minimise potential risks to participants. The consent process was treated not merely as a formal procedural requirement but as an ongoing ethical commitment throughout the research relationship. Where participants indicated sensitivity around specific topics during the interview, questions were adapted accordingly and no pressure was applied to pursue lines of inquiry that appeared to cause discomfort. Participant anonymity has been protected through the consistent use of alphabetical codes throughout the analysis, and no identifying institutional or biographical details are disclosed beyond those strictly necessary for contextual understanding. The researcher remained attentive throughout the fieldwork and the analytical process to the possibility that participants' responses may have been shaped by an awareness of potential institutional or political consequences, and this is acknowledged as an ethically significant dimension of the data rather than a methodological shortcoming to be minimised.

3.5 Researcher Reflexivity

As Finlay observes, “reflexivity in qualitative research, where researchers turn a critical gaze towards themselves, has a history spanning at least a century” (Finlay, 2003: 3). Reflexivity is not merely a procedural requirement but a substantive ethical and epistemological commitment, particularly in research that engages with politically sensitive institutional dynamics and that is shaped by the researcher’s own prior relationships with the community under study.

The researcher’s prior engagement with the ELCT through an internship placement in Tanzania between 2018 and 2019, and the professional relationships that originated during that period, were central to enabling access to participants in this study. Familiarity with the institutional context, the relational networks involved, and the political and cultural landscape of Tanzania facilitated a level of contextual understanding that would have been difficult to achieve otherwise. This prior knowledge informed the formulation of the research questions, the development of the interview guide, and the interpretive sensibility brought to the analytical process. At the same time, established relationships with participants carry the risk of influencing the dynamics of the interview encounter, potentially shaping what participants felt at liberty to disclose or how they framed their responses in relation to the researcher’s presumed expectations or institutional affiliations.

The researcher sought to mitigate this risk through the consistent use of open and non-leading questions, through explicit and repeated assurances of confidentiality at the outset of each interview, and through a sustained critical attention to the interpretive assumptions brought to the analytical process. The researcher also engaged in regular reflective writing throughout the fieldwork period, noting observations, reactions, and emerging analytical impressions in a research journal. This practice of documentation served both as a tool for developing analytical insight and as a means of maintaining critical distance from the material.

The researcher’s position as a Swedish master’s student affiliated with Uppsala University and connected to the ACT Church of Sweden through whose regional representative several participants were accessed, also carries institutional implications worth naming explicitly. This positioning may have associated the researcher in participants’ minds with ecumenical networks, normative expectations, or international institutional interests, and the possibility that this shaped the framing or content of some responses cannot be entirely discounted. The positionality are not presented as invalidating the findings of the study, but as contextual

features that are integral to a transparent and academically honest account of how the research was produced and how its results should be interpreted.

3.6 Delimitations

This study is deliberately delimited in scope and does not seek to offer a comprehensive account of the ELCT as an institution, nor of church-state relations in Tanzania more broadly. Several boundaries define and contextualise the claims the study is positioned to make, and these are acknowledged here not as shortcomings but as deliberate and reasoned choices that reflect the scale and focus appropriate to a one-year master's thesis.

The analysis is based on a purposive sample of six participants whose perspectives, while analytically rich and carefully selected, represent locations within the ELCT structure and its immediate institutional networks. The study does not include perspectives from state actors, secular civil society organisations, or non-Lutheran religious communities, all of which would offer important comparative dimensions that lie beyond the present scope. The absence of these perspectives means that the findings illuminate how certain church leaders understand and narrate their institutional roles but cannot provide a comprehensive picture of how church-state relations in Tanzania are experienced or understood across a wider range of actors.

Access to participants was facilitated through two specific relational pathways, namely the researcher's prior internship connections within the ELCT and the professional network of Lorentz Forsberg, regional representative for ACT Church of Sweden in Tanzania and East Africa. While this approach enabled access to well-placed and knowledgeable informants, the participant group is shaped to some degree by the contours of those networks, and perspectives situated outside them have not been systematically sought. This is acknowledged as a structural feature of the sampling process that carries implications for the range of institutional positions and viewpoints represented in the data.

Furthermore, as fieldwork was conducted during or in the immediate aftermath of the 2025 Tanzanian electoral period, a moment of acute political sensitivity and documented state repression, it is likely that participants exercised a degree of caution in their responses that may not have been equally present in a less charged political climate. While this contextual constraint is itself analytically significant, as it speaks directly to the conditions under which church leaders exercise public voice, it also means that certain perspectives or experiences may have remained unexpressed. The study's findings should therefore be read as situated

accounts produced within a specific and historically significant moment, rather than as definitive or exhaustive representations of the ELCT's institutional culture or leadership practice.

Results

The findings of this study are based on a thematic analysis of six interviews conducted with leaders and practitioners affiliated with the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania (ELCT/KKKT) or with organisations closely connected to it. Each interview was conducted as an individual session. In three cases, the audio recordings were divided into several files due to technical circumstances; however, these were treated as parts of one continuous conversation. To ensure confidentiality and address the political sensitivity of the research context, all names, institutional affiliations, roles, and identifying details have been anonymised. Participants are therefore referred to as P1-P6 throughout the study, in line with ethical research principles and the need to protect participants' identities.

Code	General description	Relation to ELCT	Sessions
P1	Church leader with senior ecclesiastical responsibilities	Active within ELCT leadership structure	1 (single session)
P2	Church leader with institutional programme responsibilities	Senior staff at ELCT national level	1 (single session)
P3	Church leader in senior administrative role	Senior staff at ELCT national level	1 (single session)
P4	Ordained minister and academic theologian	Ordained within ELCT; career in Lutheran ministry and theology	1 (single session)
P5	Ecumenical practitioner, gender and women's rights focus	Extensive prior work within ELCT; current partner organisation	1 (single session)
P6	Civil society and development practitioner	Current partnership with ELCT on joint programming	1 (single session)

Note: Role descriptions are intentionally broad. Specific positions, dioceses, and institutional identifiers have been omitted to protect participant confidentiality

Six themes are presented below, derived from the six thematic sections of the interview guide and reflecting the main conceptual lines along which the interviews developed. Each theme is rendered in the participants' own words as far as possible. Direct quotations are verbatim extracts attributed to the relevant participant code.

Theme 1: Peace and Justice

Every participant, without exception, rejected a narrow understanding of peace as the absence of armed conflict or public disorder. This rejection was consistent across institutional positions and professional backgrounds, suggesting that a justice-informed conception of peace is a live orientation shared by practitioners rather than an external analytical frame. P2 articulated the structural dependency between peace and justice most directly:

“I think peace goes beyond that. You have to think about peace and justice at the same time, because one of them, removal of one of them, takes away the other one. Peace is a fruit of justice, if at all it must commence. Peace without justice is just a very empty promise.” (P2)

P1 grounded this in the country´s political situation, distinguishing visible stability from genuine peace: “There can be no war, no visible conflict, and yet there is no peace. It is because probably there is repression, there is fear. People are afraid to speak, are afraid to meet.” P3 extended the understanding of peace to encompass freedom of expression and democratic participation, linking it to the political conditions prevailing in Tanzania at the time of the interviews:

“Peace is also when a person feels oppressed. The lack of peace. Being oppressed. Not being given the right to express themselves. Not given a chance to express their feelings and their views. At that point, we say also there is a political lack of peace.” (P3)

P3 connected this directly to the lived situation of families affected by the violence that followed the 2025 elections: “There are people who are being affected directly, but also their families are being affected. If someone does not know where my relative is, there is no peace... there is this shrinking space of expression in the society.” P6 offered a complementary formulation: “Peace. It is not absence of violence. It is a lot of rights. Harmony in the society. Being able to listen to opposite ideas. Being able to speak without fear.”

Despite this shared conceptual orientation, P2 observed a persistent gap between how peace is understood and how it is discussed within church settings: “A lot of people want to preach peace, but they don't want to talk about justice... Some other people think justice is related to activism, it is related to politics, and therefore they don't see it as a very valuable term to us”. This points to an institutional discourse that has selectively adopted the vocabulary of peace while avoiding the more demanding commitments justice requires. Beneath this institutional gap lies a deeper cultural dynamic identified by P5: the equation of silence with peace is not merely a political strategy imposed from above but is also internalised from childhood. “In Africa, mostly because of how we were raised, because of our norms and customs, we were raised that you have to keep quiet. You have to keep your things. Do not share. So, because of that, we pretend that we are in peace, but we are not. We are suffering.” This observation transforms the theme: the church's difficulty naming injustice is not only an institutional failure but a cultural formation that the church has reproduced and, in many respects, legitimated.

Theme 2: Church-State Relations

Participants described the relationship between the ELCT and the Tanzanian state as deeply ambivalent: cooperative in the domain of social service delivery, where the church manages a significant proportion of the country´s health and education infrastructure in formal partnership with government, but characterised in the political sphere by mutual fear, informal control, and selective co-optation. P1 first articulated what the relationship ought to be before describing what it has become:

“The relationship between the church and the state is supposed to be dialectical. It should not be animosity. It should not be friendship, but dialectical, which means everyone should keep a distance in a way that does not stop it from doing its duties.” (P1)

In practice, P1 named the operative dynamic plainly:

“From outside, there are some people who think that ELCT is co-opted in the state structure. And that the prophetic voice of ELCT is no longer there because we have compromised. But being an insider, I think the relationship between ELCT and the state is that of co-existence. There is a lot we are fearing about our government and there is a lot of unspoken fear from the government towards us.” (P1)

The most structurally specific account of co-optation came from P3, who described a deliberate state strategy of targeted financia gifts to silence potentially critical leaders: “The

government will send a person there, maybe a minister, the prime minister, or the president himself, who will say, we heard that you are constructing the church, and we will support the project by giving this amount. After that contribution, it takes quite a kind of a Jesus-like mind to say that, okay, you get this, that will not silence me. I speak against you. It is the Jesus-like mind. But for most of the normal human beings, it will work." P6 confirmed the pattern: "Some are compromised by giving a lot of gifts, some money, whatever. They say, okay, you are building a church, we will give you a hundred million. After all, if you are given that, how do you speak again?" P2 described how this strategy had deepened over time: "It has been creeping up slowly. It is getting worse now." State threats were also direct. P1 noted: "The government do threaten to close the churches. The government do threaten to do a lot of bad things to the church leaders."

P3 situated these dynamics within a longer historical oscillation, emphasising that the present passivity is not the only model the church has known:

"There is a time when the church has been active... But there are also times when the church has been passive. Sometimes we find that the relationship has been very harmonious. And it makes the church not to be very fast to speak out. There is a time the church was very outspoken, they had the Bagamoyo Declaration. They were vocal. So, it has been up and down in this relationship." (P3)

The implication is clear: when harmony with the state increases, prophetic capacity decreases. P2 named what is ultimately at stake in this oscillation, framing it as a question about the very nature of faith:

"The government needs to know that faith and faith-based organizations and faith communities are synonymous with truth. You cannot practice the faith without the truth in it. If you are using religious communities to kind of camouflage things, to polish things up... It is the most dangerous thing to do, messing around with people's faith and what they believe." (P2)

Taken together, these accounts describ a relationship in which the church´s silence is not only the product of deliberate structural pressures operating at the level of financial dependency, personal security, and the cooption of presiding leadership, but also, in P2´s formulation, a betrayal of what faith communities are fundamentally for.

Theme 3: Institutional Fragmentation

The ELCT's structural characteristics emerged as a central explanation for its institutional silence. The church is a confederation of twenty-eight autonomous dioceses, and any statement issued on behalf of the whole requires episcopal consensus convened by the presiding leadership. This means that control over whether meetings are called functions as a veto over collective institutional action. P1 described how this had been exploited: “In order to have one voice as a church, you need to bring together all 28 dioceses and come to a consensus on what to speak and what to stand for. In my view, we were infiltrated by the state organs such that whenever we try to discuss, we do not reach consensus because of division imposed on us... When the state realised that, in my view, the state went after the presiding leader, either intimidated, or compromised, or advised them not to have those meetings.”

P3 described the resulting structural incapacity for timely public response in concrete terms: “If you come up three months after the killings, you have lost the pace.” The proposed remedy was specific: a neutral research and advocacy unit within the church, a political think tank, as P3 called it, capable of rapid evidence-gathering and statement production, which the bishops could then review and own or reject. P3 also identified theological fragmentation as a compounding factor: “Someone will be preaching from the books of Romans: respect all authorities, for all the authorities are coming from God. But someone else will be preaching about injustice that has happened. So then when you have these two, it is difficult, because it is the same church contradicting.” This internal theological contradiction is not merely an intellectual disagreement; it is an institutional resource that makes consensus, already difficult by design, structurally harder to achieve.

Multiple participants offered the Roman Catholic episcopal conference as a contrasting model, consistently describing it as more unified, more outspoken, and more structurally coherent. P1 identified three structural reasons: the Catholic Church's hierarchical governance enables coordinated response across all dioceses simultaneously; its upper governance consists exclusively of ordained clergy, insulating it from the partisan lay dynamics that fragment the ELCT; and its internal solidarity mechanisms actively protect leaders who come under pressure. P6 described this solidarity culture in vivid terms:

“They have a way that once they agree, they speak all of them in the same notes. It is like either you fight them all, or you are in for it. So they have been very firm. When their General

Secretary was attacked, they were like now you cannot go out without someone with you. They create an environment to protect you." (P6)

This account points to something beyond governance structure: the Catholic conference has developed a culture of mutual protection that functions as an institutional solidarity mechanism. P1, by contrast, described feeling isolated from episcopal colleagues at precisely the moment of greatest personal danger. A proposed revision of the ELCT's internal constitution emerged across several interviews as a focal point of debate. P3 offered the most measured assessment:

"Any constitution, whether it is a country constitution or an institution constitution, is a piece of document that needs one thing to be able to be valid: respect to it. If it is not respected, it is just a piece of toilet paper. Like the country constitutions, we have a very good constitution in Tanzania. But why did, a year ago, what happened? We decided to disrespect our constitution." (P3)

Theme 4: Elections and Violence

The 2025 general election and its aftermath constitute the central empirical event around which the study is organised. Five of the six participants addressed it directly, all describing it as unprecedented in the country's history. P2 described the pre-election climate and election day itself:

"I think it is the first election in this country where people were somehow scared to go to vote. They were told before the election day that people should vote and go home and maintain safe space. They do not need to protect their votes. And then when the election commenced, there was shooting very early in the day. And then the militarisation of the country, people saw a lot of guns. Communications including internet was taken away. Internet is like oxygen these days. You take it away from people, people feel like they are suffocating." (P2)

P2 described the human consequences: "Some people who died, they could not be buried. Some people got lost and were never to be recovered. Some people running away from the hospitals because they feared persecution, you have a bullet in your body but you think that if you keep waiting at the hospital, you will be arrested and given treason charges." P1 assessed electoral legitimacy bluntly: "From the internal sources, not more than ten percent went to vote that day. And yet you had young people who went to demonstrate and ended up being

killed. They are not leading, they are ruling now." P3 drew a pointed historical contrast: "During COVID, Tanzania was not in the lockdown. But during the elections, the country saw what it means to be in the lockdown."

The official casualty figures were themselves contested. P3 noted that "the government recently said it was 541 people, but that is so much contradicted by a lot of different sources, no way, that was too little as compared to what happened." A government Commission of Inquiry was established, and P2 described the ELCT's call for it as a meaningful if limited institutional response: "We need justice to be somehow brought home." But what has not come is any public admission of responsibility. P4 named the absence that continues to define the aftermath:

"We are still waiting to hear the voice of forgiveness from our government. We are lacking it until today, as I am talking. Which, to me, it is an insult. Because if you are killing your own people, whom are you going to lead?" (P4)

The ELCT's institutional response was described across the interviews as inadequate. P1 was unambiguous: "The church did not respond. We did not respond. The church issued just a bible study, praying for the leaders, praying for peace without doing an action." P4 described the experience within the church simply: "The worst election done ever in Tanzania. The issue of silencing. That is what I experienced as a very bad thing because we were silenced... From my church, really, I did not hear any voice." A post-election care programme providing clinical pastoral support and healthcare to the injured was described by P2 as a meaningful practical response, but participants were consistent in noting that the public, prophetic response of the institution fell well short of what was needed.

Theme 5: Prophetic Agency

A persistent tension runs through the data between the shared theological conviction that the church has a prophetic mandate to speak truth to power, and the structural, personal, and political conditions that produce institutional silence. P1 described the experience of becoming, by default rather than appointment, the primary public voice of the church at a moment of crisis:

"I have been waiting for others to speak. They did not speak, so I ended up becoming a spokesperson myself. That has created another burden on me because many church leaders from all denominations are always looking at me to speak first. If I do not speak, they do not

speak, that is it. It is terrible. It is a lot of burden and a danger. Because you are exposed. The government, the impunitive government, can go after you and kill you, and they think if they kill you, then no voice will come out." (P1)

Despite this institutional isolation, P1 described an unexpected breadth of support from outside the ELCT: "I have strong support from the Roman Catholic Bishops Conference. I have strong support from the media community. I have strong support from the diplomatic community. I have strong support from global, regional, human rights coalitions. I have great and immense support from the citizens across the board, inter-religious, interfaith." P1 also described a paradox of public visibility that functions as informal protection: "These days in Tanzania, I can walk openly in cities because people are just coming out pointing to me. They want to encourage me to keep talking." This suggests that prophetic speech, once initiated, can generate its own social solidarity, even when institutional structures have withheld theirs.

P3 described a more calculated form of strategic self-censorship, motivated by a personal risk assessment: "I have been speaking out. But recently, I have not been doing much of that because you calculate: if I speak, you say that I stay here and get abducted, or I speak, then I flee from the country. Am I ready to be a political refugee? No." This produced a practice of theological indirection, raising concerns through scripture and preaching rather than direct political naming, staying below the threshold of accusation while still orienting listeners toward critical judgment. P2 named the alternative posture with a memorable image: "Some of us maybe we love selling ice cream. We want to make everyone feel like, oh yeah, this person is so good. He would not talk anything bad about you. Silence is not an answer."

P4 articulated the most expansive theological argument for prophetic engagement, insisting that the church's responsibility is not reactive but anticipatory: "The prophetic role is not to see here, what is here, but it is to see, even to try to control what will happen. Our advocates, we should do advocacy without fear." P4 also diagnosed a theological misreading that sustains silence at the congregational level: "Many Christians, many, they still feel that the political belongs to another kingdom, not their kingdom." P5 reframed the question of silence in terms of capacity rather than will, pointing toward formation rather than exhortation as the institutional intervention: "Religious leaders have enormous potential in the public space... The challenge is sometimes some of them do not have that capacity. They lack the audacity to speak about things because maybe they are not informed." P2 extended the argument toward the generational transition underway in Tanzanian religious life, connecting prophetic capacity to youth and technology:

“Our children no longer think like us. Young people of all religions united against their own faith for the truth, reconciliation, peace, peaceful coexistence, human rights. When it comes to truth, when it comes to reconciliation, when it comes to peace and justice, young people say there is no religion which can stand between us. Young people have the capacity to collect information virtually in very real life experiences. If you mix the faith with any other thing, you injure not just the church, but you also cause the diversion of what should be viewed as the faith itself, which is synonymous with truth.” (P2)

This observation situates the question of prophetic agency in a longer temporal frame: the cost of institutional silence may be measured not only in political terms but in the church's long-term credibility and relevance to its own membership.

Theme 6: Gender Justice

Two participants gave sustained attention to gender justice as an analytical theme, addressing both the internal justice deficit within the ELCT and the exclusion of women from peace processes in the wider Tanzanian society. P4 described a structural pattern that persists even where formal ordination has been granted:

“We women feel that we say, okay, we can ordain women. But we must keep them in a serving role. If you go to any church of the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania, the woman in a leadership position, apart from being in the parish, will be in the women department or Christian education department. But when you come to those positions of decision-making, women are very few.” (P4)

P4 identified the source of this pattern as a patriarchal culture that operates among women as well as men: “Understand me well, it is not the problem of men only. It is also the problem of women. Because in some of the diocese constitutions, women can be appointed to be voted for. But you find in that meeting where there are many women, men still get much more votes.” P5 connected this internal exclusion to a broader pattern of women's marginalisation from the peace and security frameworks that determine political outcomes: “Women are the weapons of wars, and they are not even included. They are excluded in peace processes framework and mediation framework. But women are very good in mediation. So sometimes if they are there, they are not proportionate. Or sometimes they can be there, but just to take the votes, not the meaningful participation.”

P5 also described ongoing harmful practices that the church has a responsibility to address, from female genital mutilation to forced marriages and the pervasive silencing of women about their own suffering, connecting all of these to the theme of surface peace: “We pretend that we are in peace, but we are not. We are suffering.” P5 raised a further dimension that extends the gender theme into the domain of pastoral wellbeing: the emotional cost borne by leaders at the most exposed positions in the church's public life, who receive little or no institutional support in processing what they witness and endure:

“Who is the counsellor of the counsellor? They have been counselling us. But when they are broken, who is there to fix them? If you have that resentment, how can you show love? How can you lead with peace, with the true and pure heart?” (P5)

This observation points to a form of institutional neglect that compounds the difficulty of sustained prophetic engagement and that, P5 suggested, falls disproportionately on those who have chosen to speak. Taken together, the accounts of P4 and P5 suggest that the church´s difficulty in speaking prophetically to the state is structurally mirrored by its difficulty in extending justice within its own institutional life, and that the two failures are connected rather than separate.

Remarkable Findings

These findings are drawn from the interview material and carry analytical weight beyond what the thematic structure captures. They are presented here because they are likely to be of direct relevance to the thesis argument and invite a comparison with broader scholarly discussion of religious actors, civil society, and resistance in contexts of democratic backslidings

Finding 1: The Waqrislam Movement:

During and after the 2025 election, a spontaneous youth inter-faith solidarity movement emerged that poses significant questions for how prophetic agency is theorised in a context where established religious institutions have been silenced or co-opted. Understanding Waqrislam requires first understanding the political strategy that provoked it. The current head of state is a Muslim woman, the first in the country's history. When Roman Catholic leaders and outspoken church figures began publicly demanding accountability for election violence, certain Muslim religious leaders and state-aligned voices reframed these demands as evidence of religious and gender prejudice, depicting prophetic critique as an attack on a

Muslim female president. P2 described the mechanism: “We saw some faith leaders, especially from Muslims, changing the story. Maybe the president is being attacked because she is from an Islamic religion, which is not true.” The strategy was designed to split the religious landscape along denominational lines at precisely the moment when ecumenical solidarity might have been strongest, and to discredit prophetic speech by associating it with sectarianism.

The youth response was extraordinary in its directness. Young people, Christian and Muslim, formed an impromptu solidarity movement that explicitly refused the religious boundary-marking being deployed against them. P2 described its emergence and the significance of its name:

“The youth decided to show solidarity, youth from different groups. They created even a new terminology, Waqrislam, which is a Christian-Muslim kind of group. They mixed the Christian-Muslim kind of virtual religion, which they were calling themselves Waqrislam. It is like Christian and Muslim's one faith. And these folks, they believed for them they did not have boundaries for either being Christian or Muslim. Their religion was mainly focusing on human rights and rights approaches. To see that the person who speaks the truth, the person who is God-fearing, the person who respects the sanctity of life as a crucial issue, needs their respect and was part of their religion.” (P2)

The name is itself analytically significant: a portmanteau of the Swahili plural forms for Christian (Wakristo) and Muslim (Waislamu). Its content is defined not by doctrine but by ethical commitment, to truth, accountability, and the sanctity of human life. The movement went further than naming. P2 described the symbolic acts through which young people crossed religious boundaries at their most sacred moments:

“It happened during the holy month of Ramadan, and it was Lent for Christians. And young people, I saw Muslims say, if it means that we just want to prove our sheikhs wrong, we will eat pork. Just to prove our case that we are one. And we were hearing Christian young people say, well, we will go and eat iftar with Muslims. We will go to mosque on Friday and we will go to church on Sunday. Just to prove that we do not belong to anyone and we cannot be domesticated.” (P2)

To publicly offer to violate the dietary and ritual requirements of one´s own tradition at its most sacred moment is a maximally visible declaration that no religious authority, neither sheikh nor bishop, can claim ownership of young people´s political conscience. P2 reflected

on the movement with a mixture of admiration and concern: “I think that was very powerful but I think it was also scary. For somebody who really thinks, I think we were pushing our young people way too far. Because they know the reality, they know the truth. They saw it with their naked eyes. Some of the young people were shot at, were injured, were put in jail and were given some very bad cases like treason. Which in real life, it was just to scare them off. To make proof that they cannot be scared off.” P2 concluded with a broader theological observation: “When it comes to truth, when it comes to reconciliation, when it comes to peace and justice, young people say there is no religion which can stand between us. They know the reality; they know the truth. They saw it with their naked eyes. To make proof that they cannot be scared off.” Waqrislam represents a form of grassroots inter-faith solidarity that emerged without institutional religious leadership and partly against it. Young people did not cease to be Christian or Muslim, but they refused to allow those identities to be instrumentalised as political weapons. This raises a question of direct relevance to the thesis: when established religious institutions fail to produce prophetic solidarity, can informal civil religious movements perform a similar function, and if so, under what conditions can such movements be sustained?

Finding 2: The Culture of Silence as a Structural Phenomenon

Several participants describe silence in the face of injustice as operating not only as a political response to state repression, but as a deeply socialised cultural norm that complicates any analysis attributing institutional quietism primarily to fear or moral failure. P5´s account is the most direct: “In Africa, mostly because of how we were raised, because of our norms and customs, we were raised that you must keep quiet. You must keep your things. Do not share. So, because of that, we pretend that we are in peace, but we are not. Sometimes you feel it inside, but you cannot give it out.” P4 provided a theological dimension by invoking Luther's concept of incurvatus in se: the church turned inward on itself, looking at its own concerns rather than outward toward the world it is called to serve. The analytical significance of this finding is that the culture of silence is overdetermined. It is simultaneously a cultural norm of quiet endurance, a theological misunderstanding in which political life is treated as belonging to a separate kingdom, a structural condition in which the state actively suppresses voice, and an institutional pattern in which the church replicates internally the failures it lacks the capacity to name externally. These layers reinforce each other, which suggests that strategies for change will need to operate at multiple levels simultaneously rather than addressing any single dimension in isolation.

Finding 3: The Moral Authority Paradox

The church is identified by one participant as the most powerful civil society actor remaining in Tanzanian public life, and yet its institutional authority is almost entirely dormant. This paradox is one of the sharpest formulations in the dataset. P6 stated: “Given the public space shrinking in Tanzania, the church is the only moral civil society that has remained strong. And if it is used properly, it is the only one that can bring changes in this country. Because the government can shunt all the issues, but not the church.” The church possesses more potential moral authority than any other institution in the country precisely because it retains an independence and credibility that purely political institutions no longer have. And yet it has chosen, for the reasons documented across the six themes, not to exercise that authority at the moments when it was most needed. The result is that its authority is simultaneously enormous in potential and largely dormant in practice. The Waqrislam movement may suggest that young people have already begun to occupy the moral space that established institutions have left vacant.

Finding 4: Covert support from within the state

One participant describes receiving private expressions of support and confidential information from cabinet-level officials who encourage public speech they cannot make themselves. This significantly complicates any binary account of church-state relations. P1 stated: “I even enjoy support from the government, but by secrecy. I have cabinet members, appointed people in the high government offices who reach out to me in inbox and tell me things that are horrible.” This observation suggests that there are individuals within the state apparatus who are themselves dissenting from the direction of government policy but lack the institutional position or personal security to do so publicly. The church leader's public voice functions, in this account, as a proxy for forms of political conscience that exist within the state but cannot find direct expression. This has implications both for how the church-state relationship is theorised and for how the space of civic resistance is understood in a context of democratic backsliding.

Analysis

Read together, the six themes and four remarkable findings point toward a configuration of structural and cultural conditions that interact to produce the ELCT's institutional silence, a configuration that Giddens´ structuration theory is well-suited to illuminate. The cultural norm of silence that P5 describes, internalised from childhood and reproduced across all levels of society independently of any direct state threat, is in Giddens´ terms a structural rule that actors draw upon and recursively reproduce in their social practice. It is simultaneously the medium and the outcome of the practices through which silence becomes the default response to injustice. This is what Giddens calls the duality of structure: the church does not simply operate within a culture of silence; it actively reproduces that culture in every sermon that does not name injustice, in every pastoral encounter that counsels quiet endurance, in every decision not to convene a meeting that might produce a prophetic statement. The state´s financial co-optation of church leaders adds an allocative resource dimension: by distributing material benefits strategically, the state draws leaders into a web of dependency that makes prophetic speech feel costly and gratitude feel virtuous. As P3 put it, the genius of the strategy lies precisely in its appeal to ordinary human psychology: “It takes quite a kind of a Jesus-like mind to say that, okay, you get this, but that will not silence me.” The ELCT's confederal governance structure constitutes a specific authoritative resource, namely the presiding leader's control over whether meetings are convened, that a determined state actor can exploit to paralyse collective institutional response without ever issuing a direct order. The duality of structure is visible here in its most troubling form: the very institutional arrangements that give the ELCT its reach and coordination capacity are simultaneously the mechanisms through which its prophetic agency is suppressed.

The comparison with the Roman Catholic Church, which appears across multiple interviews without prompting, illuminates this further. The difference in response during the 2025 crisis is not primarily a difference in the courage or theological formation of individual leaders; it is a difference in institutional architecture. As P6 observed, the Catholic conference has a culture of mutual protection that translates directly into prophetic capacity: when you must fight them all to silence one, the cost of repression rises sharply for the state. Giddens´concept of transformative capacity, understood as the relational ability to produce outcomes that would not otherwise have occurred, is here unevenly distributed between two institutions occupying the same social and political space. P6´s observation that the church remains “the only moral civil society that has remained strong” points to a form of symbolic and moral authority

constituting significant transformative potential, but potential that is currently unrealised because the structural conditions for its deployment are blocked. The theological fragmentation P3 identifies compounds this: the church cannot speak with one voice in part because it cannot agree theologically on whether speaking is its role. P3 describes two bishops simultaneously preaching from the same church, one citing Romans 13 to counsel submission to authority, another naming the injustice that authority has committed. This is not merely an intellectual disagreement; it is a structural condition that makes consensus effectively impossible.

Brueggemann´s account of prophetic witness provides a complementary diagnostic frame. His argument is that the prophetic task is to nurture and evoke an alternative consciousness capable of critiquing the dominant order and energising communities toward transformation. The ELCT's alternative vocation has been, in his terms, co-opted and domesticated, not by a single dramatic intervention but through the slow accumulation of financial dependencies, governance vulnerabilities, and cultural norms of non-expression that each independently seemed manageable. P2´s observation that the state's strategy of co-optation has been "creeping up slowly" and "getting worse now" is a nearly precise empirical description of the process Brueggemann theorises. Crucially, Brueggemann insists that the prophet speaks not as an individual innovator but as a child of the tradition, drawing on resources already present in the community's memory to name the present moment. The Bagamoyo Declaration that P3 invokes is precisely such a resource: a moment when the ELCT was vocal, outspoken, willing to name power. The question the analysis raises is whether that memory can be recovered as a living resource or whether it has become merely historical, a monument to a prophetic capacity the institution no longer knows how to exercise.

Casanova's deprivatisation thesis sharpens this further. The state's insistence that the church does not mix religion and politics is precisely the privatisation move that Casanova argues democratic societies cannot afford. It is a demand that religious institutions confine themselves to the management of individual spiritual life and refrain from making public claims about justice, governance, or accountability. P2´s counter-claim, that faith and faith-based organisations are "synonymous with truth" and that messing around with people´s faith is "the most dangerous thing to do", is not a violation of democratic norms but an assertion of them. It is a claim that the moral resources of religious traditions belong in shared public life rather than sequestered in the private sphere. Habermas would describe this as the church refusing communicative withdrawal: insisting that its voice belong to the public sphere of

reasons, where claims must be argued and answered, rather than silenced before they can be made. The institutional failure of the ELCT is, from this perspective, a withdrawal from communicative life, a retreat into a managed silence that leaves the public sphere diminished and the dominant narrative unchallenged.

Lederach´s framework of reconciliation as social space, the meeting place where truth, mercy, justice, and peace can encounter one another, illuminates what both the ELCT's silence and the Waqrislam movement represent. Lederach draws on the image of Psalm 85:10, in which justice and peace kiss: reconciliation is not a state to be achieved but a relational space to be held open. The ELCT's silence closes that space. By refusing to name injustice, the church removes one of the necessary parties from the encounter: truth cannot meet mercy if truth is never spoken. Waqrislam, by contrast, created precisely such a social space, impromptu, fragile, and costly for its participants, but genuine. P2 describes it in terms that echo Lederach directly:

“When it comes to truth, when it comes to reconciliation, when it comes to peace and justice, young people say there is no religion which can stand between us. They know the reality; they know the truth. They saw it with their naked eyes.” (P2)

This is the social space of reconciliation named from below, by people who paid the price for entering it. The question the analysis leaves open is whether formal religious institutions can learn from such movements, or whether the structural conditions that produced the movements also prevent the institutions from receiving what the movements embody.

Discussion

The most significant theoretical contribution of this material may lie in what it reveals about where prophetic agency locates itself when formal religious institutions fail to exercise it. Arendt's concept of natality, the ontological openness of the social world to genuinely new beginnings that cannot be predicted from what precedes them, finds its most vivid empirical expression in the Waqrislam movement. Arendt writes that “the new always appears in the guise of a miracle” precisely because it could not have been deduced from the conditions that preceded it (Arendt, 1958: 246). The movement did not emerge from institutional planning or ecumenical negotiation; it emerged from below, in direct response to a political strategy designed to close the space for moral speech by weaponising religious identity. In Arendtian terms, it constitutes a new beginning that interrupted what P2 called the domestication of

young people by religious and political establishments simultaneously. The declaration that their religion was defined by human rights, truth, and the sanctity of life rather than by doctrinal boundary-markers is a form of public disclosure, an act of appearing before others and announcing who one is, that carries the full weight Arendt assigns to political action. The symbolic acts P2 describes are not accidental:

“Young people, I saw Muslims say, if it means that we just want to prove our sheikhs wrong, we will eat pork. Just to prove our case that we are one. And we were hearing Christian young people say, well, we will go and eat iftar with Muslims. We will go to mosque on Friday and we will go to church on Sunday. Just to prove that we do not belong to anyone and we cannot be domesticated.” (P2)

To violate one´s own tradition´s most sacred dietary and ritual boundaries in public is not apostasy; it is a claim about who has authority over the meaning of religious identity. Waqrislam is also, by the same token, irreversibly fragile: what natality begins, structural pressures can overwhelm. The arrests, the treason charges, the personal costs borne by participants, are the evidence that new beginnings are not protected by their own moral clarity. Whether Waqrislam can develop the institutional memory and relational networks needed to sustain pressure beyond the crisis that called it into being remains, as Arendt would expect, radically open.

A second theoretical contribution concerns the relationship between internal and external justice failures. The institutional silence of the ELCT during the 2025 elections cannot be fully understood without reference to its internal governance failures, particularly the decades-long gap between deciding to ordain women and implementing that decision across all dioceses. P4´s invocation of incurvatus in se as a diagnosis is not merely rhetorical; it names an institutional pathology in which the same disposition that produces internal injustice, the church looking inward rather than outward, also produces external silence. The failure to hear any voice from the institution at the moment of greatest need is continuous with the failure to ensure meaningful participation of women in decision-making at every level. P4's question about the government's silence applies, with different but not unrelated force, to the church itself:

“We are still waiting to hear the voice of forgiveness from our government. We are lacking it until today, as I am talking. Which, to me, it is an insult. Because if you are killing your own people, whom are you going to lead?” (P4)

Arendt´s analysis of the banality of evil is directly relevant here: the most morally consequential failures are often not dramatic acts of malice but the ordinary abdication of independent judgment in the face of institutional pressure. The leaders who received government money and stayed silent were, in this sense, not simply weak individuals; they were participants in a structural reproduction of quietism that each individual act of deference made slightly more entrenched. Casanova's deprivatisation thesis is also instructive here: the state´s insistence that the church not mix religion and politics is precisely the privatisation move that Casanova argues democratic societies cannot afford. P2´s counter-claim, that religious work is actually political and that "faith communities are synonymous with truth", is not a violation of democratic norms but an assertion of them, a claim that the moral resources of religious traditions belong in shared public life rather than sequestered in the private sphere.

A third contribution concerns what the study reveals about the relationship between prophetic speech, institutional protection, and personal courage. The contrast between P1´s experience, speaking publicly, generating solidarity, and eventually finding that visibility itself becomes a form of protection, and P3´s calculated retreat from public speech illustrates that prophetic agency is not simply a function of individual moral formation. It is also a function of the institutional and relational infrastructure within which individuals operate. P1 describes something close to what Arendt calls the courage of disclosure: the willingness to appear before others and speak, knowing that this appearance carries risk. But P1 also notes that the appearance generated its own support: "these days in Tanzania, I can walk openly in cities because people are just coming out pointing to me." This suggests that the relationship between prophetic speech and institutional protection is not linear. Speech does not wait for protection before it becomes possible; sometimes speech creates the conditions of its own protection. The implication for how the church theorises prophetic courage is significant: the question is not only how to protect individuals before they speak, but how to develop the institutional conditions in which speaking begins.

The generational dimension that P2 identifies deserves particular attention as a finding about the future trajectory of both the church and civil society in Tanzania. P2´s observation that "our children no longer think like us" is not simply a sociological observation about changing attitudes; it is a claim about where the resources for prophetic agency are being reconstituted outside the institutions that were supposed to carry them. Habermas´s concept of communicative rationality suggests that the public sphere requires participants who are

oriented toward mutual understanding rather than strategic advantage. The Waqrislam movement embodies this orientation in an acute form: its participants refused the strategic instrumentalisation of religious identity and insisted instead on the publicly accountable claim that truth, justice, and the sanctity of life are values that cross doctrinal lines. This is precisely the kind of communicative action Habermas argues is constitutive of democratic public life, and it emerged from young people with smartphones, not from episcopal synods with constitutions.

Conclusion

The six interviews conducted for this study provide a rich and at times painful account of a religious institution confronting a political crisis for which it was structurally and culturally unprepared. Read through the theoretical framework that guides this thesis, the ELCT´s institutional response to the 2025 elections is best understood not as a failure of individual courage but as the outcome of a structurally overdetermined silence. The rules and resources that Giddens identifies as constitutive of social structure, the cultural norm of non-expression, the financial dependencies created by state co-optation, the governance arrangements that concentrate veto power in a single presiding role, the theological misreading that removes political life from the sphere of Christian responsibility, all operated simultaneously to suppress collective prophetic agency at the moment it was most urgently needed. P1's vision of what the church-state relationship ought to be, dialectical, maintaining creative distance, refusing both animosity and friendship, was not simply an ideal; it was a description of the structural condition the church needs to defend to remain capable of prophetic speech. That condition has been progressively eroded, not all at once but through the slow accumulation of dependencies, silences, and governance vulnerabilities that each individually seemed manageable.

At the same time, the data confirm Giddens´ insistence that structure is never only constraining: the same moral credibility and institutional presence that the state sought to manage and contain also generated the conditions under which individual leaders continued to speak, pastoral care reached the injured, and, outside the institutional structures entirely, young people across religious lines refused to allow their faith identities to be used as instruments of political division. P5´s question about who counsels the counsellors, who sustains the leaders who sustain others, points to a form of institutional neglect that has costs not only for individuals but for the long-term capacity of the church to remain a site of

prophetic formation. It is a question the church has not yet adequately answered: “If you have that resentment, how can you show love? How can you lead with peace, with the true and pure heart?” This is not a peripheral concern. It is at the heart of whether the church can recover the prophetic capacity the current moment requires.

Waqrislam deserves particular emphasis as both an empirical finding and a theoretical provocation. In Arendt's terms, it is an instance of natality, a genuinely unprecedented beginning that interrupted the expected trajectory of religious division and institutional silence. Its content, human rights, truth, the sanctity of life, is continuous with the prophetic tradition that Brueggemann describes as the church's alternative vocation; but it emerged from below and outside the institution, precisely because that vocation had been, in his terms, co-opted and domesticated within it. The movement also enacts Casanova´s deprivatisation thesis in its most radical form: these young people did not merely claim a place for religious voices in public deliberation; they reconstituted the category of religious identity itself, making it coextensive with ethical commitment rather than doctrinal membership. Whether this form of civil religious solidarity can be sustained beyond the crisis that called it into being is one of the most important questions the study leaves open.

Galtung´s distinction between negative and positive peace, which every participant in this study articulated in their own terms, without prompting and without using Galtung's vocabulary, provides the normative standard against which all these questions must ultimately be assessed. P2 named it most plainly at the outset: “Peace without justice is just a very empty promise.” That formulation functions as both the study´s point of departure and its conclusion. The church was asked, at a moment of acute crisis, to embody the peace it preaches, not the empty peace of institutional stability, but the demanding peace that requires truth, accountability, and the willingness to speak on behalf of those whose voices have been suppressed. What the interviews collectively describe is an institution that knows this calling theologically but has not yet developed the structural, relational, and cultural conditions to live it consistently. The gap between what the church believes about peace and what it does in its name is the central finding of this study, and closing that gap is the task the interviews, taken together, insistently propose.

Several directions for future research follow from this analysis. A study engaging directly with church leaders who chose silence in their own terms would provide a fuller account of the institutional culture of quietism, including the theological arguments that sustain it and the conditions under which they might change. The Waqrislam movement itself merits direct

empirical investigation: the social networks through which it formed, the costs borne by participants, and any institutional relationships, however informal, it may have developed with existing civil society or ecumenical structures. A comparative study examining prophetic capacity across denominations and across multiple political moments in Tanzania would allow the structural factors identified here to be tested against a longer historical baseline and a wider institutional range. And the relationship between internal church reform and external prophetic capacity, suggested by the contrast between the ELCT and the Roman Catholic episcopal conference, deserves dedicated theoretical attention: under what conditions do religious institutions develop and sustain the structural prerequisites for coordinated prophetic speech, and what relationship does internal justice, including the full implementation of women's ordination and meaningful inclusion in decision-making, bear to that capacity?

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Appendix 1: Interview guide

Interview Guide

Between Faith and Power: Church Leadership, Agency, and Peace with Justice in Tanzania

Opening: Thank you for taking the time to speak with me. This interview is part of a study examining how leaders within the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania (ELCT) understand and exercise their role and agency in relation to peace, justice, and political authority in the current Tanzanian context. The conversation will take approximately 45-60 minutes. With your permission, I will record the interview for transcription purposes. Your participation is voluntary; you may decline to answer any question and may stop the interview at any time. Everything you share will be treated confidentially, and I will discuss anonymity with you before any material is used.

1. Background and role (warm-up)

Q1. Could you describe your current role and how you came to it and possibly your connections ot ELCT/KKKT? How long have you served in this role? What were your previous roles within the church or in public life?

Q2. How do you understand the responsibilities of church leaders in Tanzanian society today? To what extent do you feel that church leaders have room to act independently in this context?

2. Peace, justice, and church discourse

Q3. When you speak about peace in the Tanzanian context, what does the concept mean to you? Do you distinguish between peace as stability and peace as something broader, such as justice? Could you give an example?

Q4. How are questions of peace and justice discussed within the ELCT (for example in preaching, teaching, or pastoral letters)? Are there particular theological, biblical, or institutional references that shape these discussions?

Q5. What kinds of societal issues are currently discussed within the church as matters of concern? How are decisions made about whether, and how, the church should respond to such issues?

3. Church, state, and political authority

Q6. How would you describe the relationship between the ELCT and the Tanzanian state today? In what ways is this relationship cooperative, and in what ways does it require caution?

Q7. Could you describe a situation where political developments raised concerns about justice or human dignity, and how you or the church responded? How did you decide whether, and how, to act in that situation?

Q8. Is there a Christian leader, living or deceased, in Tanzania or elsewhere, whom you particularly look up to when it comes to speaking out or acting politically as a Christian leader? What is it about this person's example that you find meaningful or instructive?

Q9. In your view, is there a church or ecumenical organisation, in Tanzania or more broadly, that you think does particularly good work when it comes to peace, justice, and political engagement? What makes their approach effective?

Q10. How do you understand the relationship between church and state more broadly? In what circumstances, and to what extent, do you see it as the responsibility of church leaders to act or speak publicly on political matters?

(Optional, if relevant)

Q11. Looking back at the period around the 2025 elections, how did you experience that time as a church leader? Were there particular moments that stood out, and how did the church respond?

4. Internal dynamics and decision-making

Q12. How are decisions made within the ELCT when considering whether to issue a public statement on a sensitive issue? Who is involved in the process, and how are different perspectives handled?

Q13. Have there been situations where leaders within the church have held differing views on how to respond to political or social issues? How were these differences managed, and what helped maintain unity?

5. Agency, constraints, and strategy

Q14. What do you see as the main constraints on church leaders when considering whether to speak publicly on matters of justice? Are these constraints political, institutional, theological, financial, or of another kind?

Q15. What strategies do you use to address sensitive issues while protecting the church's mission and its members? For example, through sermons, pastoral letters, private dialogue, ecumenical cooperation, or international networks, could you describe one concrete example?

Q16. How do you understand the moral authority of the church in Tanzania today? How do you reflect on public criticism regarding the church's level of engagement in political or social issues?

6. Looking forward and closing

Q17. Looking ahead, what role do you hope the ELCT will play in Tanzania's political and social life? What would enable the church to play this role, and what might limit it?

Q18. Is there anything important regarding church leadership, peace, or justice in Tanzania that we have not discussed, but that you believe this study should consider? Are there other individuals you would recommend I speak with?

Closing: Thank you very much for your time and for sharing your reflections. I will treat what you have said with care. If you would like, I can share a summary of the study's findings once the research is complete. Please feel free to contact me afterwards if there is anything you would like to add, clarify, or withdraw.

Appendix 2: Informed consent form

Informed Consent

Title of Research: Between Faith and Power: Church Leadership, Agency, and Peace with Justice in Tanzania

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1. Introduction and Purpose of the Study

You are invited to take part in a research study examining how leaders within the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania (ELCT) understand and exercise agency in relation to peace, justice, and political authority in the contemporary Tanzanian context. This study is part of a master's thesis in Religion, Peace, and Conflict Studies at Uppsala University. The research aims to understand how church leaders navigate internal institutional tensions and external political pressures, and how they articulate positions related to justice, peace, and political authority.

This study will seek to answer the following questions:

- How do leaders within the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania exercise and understand agency in relation to peace and justice in the current political context?

- How is the concept of peace-with-justice articulated within church discourse and leadership statements, and how do church leaders interpret their role in relation to political authority?
- How do internal disagreements within the ELCT and external political pressures influence the church's public positioning and institutional action?

2. Description of the Research
If you agree to participate, you will be asked to take part in one semi-structured interview. The interview will include questions about your experiences as a church leader or theologian, your views on peace and justice, and how you navigate the relationship between the church and political authority. Interviews will be recorded to ensure accuracy.

Subject Participation
This study will include participants connected to the Evangelical Lutheran Church in Tanzania, such as church leaders, bishops, and theologians familiar with church-state relations. To take part, you must be over 18 and have relevant knowledge of or a role within the ELCT or related institutions. Your participation is expected to take about 45-75 minutes.

4. Potential Risks and Discomforts
There are no known major risks from participating in this study. Some questions may touch on sensitive or emotional topics. If you feel uncomfortable, you may skip any question or stop the interview at any time. If needed, the researcher will help connect you to local support services. There are no direct personal benefits to participating. However, your contribution may help raise awareness and contribute to academic and peacebuilding discussions about the role of religious institutions in democratic resilience and civil society engagement in Tanzania.

There is no payment or compensation for participating in this study.

6. Confidentiality
Your identity will not be disclosed in any reports, presentations, or publications resulting from this study. While complete anonymity cannot be guaranteed, every effort will be made to protect your privacy and ensure that no identifying details are included. All interviews and field notes will be securely stored and coded, and only the researcher will have access to this material. Audio recordings will be deleted once they have been transcribed and the data has been analysed.

8. Voluntary Participation and Authorization
Your participation is completely voluntary. You may choose not to participate or to withdraw at any time. This decision will not affect your relationship with any organisation, church, or service involved in the study.

You may withdraw at any time. If you wish to do so, please inform the researcher directly. If you withdraw after the interview, any data you provided can still be used, unless you request otherwise.

Authorization and Consent

Please indicate your willingness to participate in this study:

☐ *Yes, I voluntarily agree to participate in this study.*

Name of Participant (print): _____

Signature: _____

Date: _____